word is our honour. We believe in self-control, self-discipline, humility and loyalty. We serve our school and protect its good name in word and deed. We keep ourselves and our environment immaculate and clean. We stand for our Language, our Nation and our Country.

Ninety-eight times, 99 times ... 100.

I was one of those new and nervous boys and, as we completed the task, I looked across the hall and happened to catch the eye of a friend I had first met two years earlier at the South African primary schools cricket week, where he was playing for Northern Transvaal and I was a member of the Northern Province side. He nodded at me and smiled in unspoken acknowledgement of a job well done.

It was not the first time we had risen to a challenge together, nor would it be the last.

My friend in the school hall was Francois du Plessis, or 'Faf', as he was and is universally known. He was in the same year as me at high school, most often in the same class, usually in the same sports team and always in the same boarding house; from those days through all these years, we have been teammates at Affies, teammates in the Titans provincial side and teammates in the South African national team.

Faf and I have walked a long road together. Through countless training sessions and matches, countless trips and tours, scrapes and adventures, we have got to know each other extremely well and have become close friends and eager rivals, forever spurring each other to greater achievements.

Looking back, the image of us that endures in my mind is of two excited high-school boys fielding side by side in the covers, prowling like hungry wild animals, literally pouncing on the ball at every opportunity, supporting each other, challenging each other to be faster and more agile, to concentrate harder.